

MODULE 1 | PRE-SESSION READING

Dignity, Respect & Psychological Safety at Work

Before your first live session, please read this short primer. You do not need any prior knowledge of POSH. Its purpose is to help you understand the human and cultural foundation behind the law - why dignity, respectful boundaries and the confidence to speak up matter before we begin studying legal definitions and procedures.

Why this reading comes before the law

POSH is often introduced as legislation, a policy or a complaint process. But the reason those mechanisms exist is fundamentally human: people should be able to work without being humiliated, sexualised, intimidated or made to feel unsafe. A strong POSH programme therefore begins by understanding the culture the law is trying to protect.

1. Dignity: the non-negotiable baseline

Dignity means recognising the inherent worth of every person at work. It is reflected in how colleagues speak to one another, how power is exercised, how boundaries are respected and how concerns are handled. Dignity does not depend on designation, seniority or popularity.

- People are treated respectfully, even when there is disagreement or performance pressure.
- Personal and professional boundaries are recognised rather than tested or trivialised.
- Concerns are heard without ridicule, retaliation or unnecessary exposure.

2. Respect: what we do matters

Respect is visible in everyday behaviour - the jokes we make, the comments we normalise, the messages we send, the way we respond to a 'no', and what leaders reward, challenge or ignore. Good intention does not automatically make conduct appropriate. Workplace behaviour must also be understood through context, boundaries and whether it is welcome.

3. Boundaries: comfort and consent can change

Workplace boundaries are not fixed forever. A person may be comfortable with an interaction at one time and uncomfortable later. A friendly relationship, previous consent or informal workplace culture does not remove another person's right to set or change a boundary. Respect means noticing and responding appropriately when a boundary is communicated.

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Connecting Culture to POSH

4. Psychological safety: the ability to speak up

Psychological safety is the confidence to ask questions, raise concerns, report inappropriate behaviour or say no without fearing professional cost. It does not mean every conversation will be comfortable or that every concern will produce a preferred outcome. It means people can use workplace processes without being silenced, mocked or punished for speaking up.

5. Belonging and equity: strengthening trust

Belonging means people feel included, valued and able to contribute. Equity means people are treated fairly while recognising that individuals may start from different positions or need different forms of support. Together, these conditions influence whether employees trust workplace systems enough to raise concerns when something feels wrong.

Connect the dots

Dignity	Respect	Boundaries	Psychological Safety	Speak Up	POSH Prevention & Redressal
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So, where does POSH fit?

POSH stands for the prevention of sexual harassment at the workplace. In India, the POSH Act, 2013 creates statutory protection against workplace sexual harassment for women and establishes responsibilities for prevention, prohibition and redressal. Broader organisational policies may provide protections for everyone. During the programme, we will study the law in detail; for now, remember the purpose behind it: a workplace in which dignity and boundaries are respected and people can raise concerns safely and fairly.

A POSH trainer's role is therefore not only to explain rules. It is to help people recognise boundaries, understand responsible behaviour, know how to seek support, and build confidence in fair workplace processes.

Before Session: pause and reflect

- What makes people feel respected in a workplace?
- What behaviours or organisational practices can make people hesitate to speak up?
- What responsibility should a POSH trainer carry when discussing sensitive workplace behaviour?

There are no "right" answers to these reflection questions. Bring your thoughts with you to the first live session.